

CORE FORMULA

Long form: Given [specific context], it makes sense that [reaction] would show up. That does not mean [the problem] is okay; it means your response has a reason. What would help now? -> **Short form:** context -> reaction -> dignity -> distinction -> next step. -> **Pocket formula:** "Given X, Y makes sense. That does not make X okay." -> **Safety line:** use it to increase clarity, ease and respect, never to pressure, corner or talk someone out of a reasonable standard.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Given [specific context], it makes sense that [reaction] would show up.

BEST FOR

- Someone says or implies "Maybe I am overreacting", "I should be over this", or "Is it weird that I feel this?"
- Shame, embarrassment, anxiety, self-blame or isolation after a difficult interaction.
- Work conversations where pressure, uncertainty or repeated changes have made a strong reaction understandable.
- Repair conversations where a person's reaction needs to be acknowledged as reasonable before you discuss next steps.
- Helping, coaching, friendship and leadership contexts where dignity matters as much as accuracy.

PHRASE BANK

Quick one-liners · Short, in-the-moment

- "That makes sense in context."
- "You are not wrong for feeling that."
- "That reaction has a reason."
- "Given the situation, that is understandable."
- "Makes sense, given everything around it."
- "You are not overreacting."
- "That one has a reason behind it."

Social and personal · Friends, family, partner

- "Given how sudden that was, it makes sense you feel thrown."
- "You are not strange for reacting strongly to something that touched that many nerves."
- "That reaction has a reason. It does not mean the situation was okay."
- "A lot of people would feel unsettled after that, especially with the history around it."
- "Given how much had built up, it makes sense your body reacted. That does not make you weak."
- "Given the history around that topic, it makes sense it lands with extra weight."

Work and process · Team, meeting, leadership

- "Given the unclear handoff, it makes sense the team felt exposed."
- "That concern is understandable in a process where expectations kept changing."
- "A strong reaction here is not automatically overreaction; the conditions created real pressure."
- "It makes sense that trust would be dented after repeated scope changes."
- "Given the repeated changes, it makes sense people are frustrated."
- "A strong reaction is understandable under that much ambiguity."

Digital and text · Messages, email, chat

- "Given the timing, I can see why that message landed badly."

- "That read as abrupt, so it makes sense it raised a flag."
- "I do not mean "normal" as in fine; I mean your reaction makes sense in context."
- "It makes sense this felt bigger than one message."
- "I can see why that message felt abrupt. I do not mean to make that sound small."

Reaction, not the problem · Separate understandable from acceptable

- "That does not mean the situation was okay."
- "Before we solve it, I want to say the reaction makes sense."
- "The reaction is data that the process needs clarity."
- "Let us separate the frustration from the next fix."
- "We still need to decide what to change, and your reaction still makes sense."
- "Your response has a reason, and the situation still needs attention."

High-pressure moments · Stakes, urgency, alarm

- "Given the stakes, it makes sense your body went straight to alert mode."
- "That is a human response to pressure, not a character flaw."
- "Given the timing and the impact, I can see why this feels serious."
- "Under that much pressure, a strong reaction is understandable."

Recovery and repair · When it lands wrong

- "I do not mean to minimise it."
- "Normal does not mean acceptable."
- "Let me say that more carefully."
- "I am not saying you should just be fine with it."
- "I do not mean "normal" as in acceptable. I mean your reaction makes sense."
- "I am not trying to shrink what happened."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "That is normal." Too generic; it can sound like dismissal or a cue to stop feeling it.
Better: "A lot of people would feel that way." Warmer, but still broad and not anchored to their situation.
Best: "Given how sudden the change was, it makes sense you feel thrown. That does not make the change okay; it just means your reaction has a reason." Specific, respectful, and careful not to normalise the problem.
2. Weak: "It's just how projects go." Normalises the churn itself, so it excuses the process.
Better: "A lot of teams get frustrated by changes." Kinder, but generic and unanchored.
Best: "Given the repeated scope changes, it makes sense trust took a hit. That does not make the churn acceptable; it means the reaction has a reason." Anchored, and it keeps the problem in view.

DECISION TREE

If There is a shame or isolation cue, e.g. "maybe I'm overreacting".

Consider careful normalising rather than advice or a question.

"Given the context, that reaction makes sense."

If You do not have enough specific context yet.

Check before interpreting (TC064) first; do not guess your way into a normaliser.

"Can I check I've got the picture right before I say anything?"

If Normalising could excuse harm or poor process.

Explicitly separate the reaction from the problem.

"Your reaction makes sense - that does not make the behaviour okay."

If They soften or elaborate.

Continue with reflection, support or a next-step question.

"What would help right now?"

If They push back, e.g. "don't minimise it".

Recover, drop the frame, and ask what needs attention.

"I don't mean to shrink it. What part most needs attention?"

If They need action now.

Stop reassuring and move to concrete support, boundary, repair or decision.

"Okay - let's decide what actually changes."

SCENARIOS

Friend embarrassed after crying.

Normalise the build-up, not their strength; then ask what support they want. — "Given how much had built up, it makes sense your body reacted. That doesn't make you weak."

Colleague angry after process churn.

Treat the reaction as signal, then move toward ownership and next steps. — "Given the repeated changes, it makes sense people are frustrated. The reaction is data that the process needs clarity."

Customer reacting strongly to a service failure.

Acknowledge why it feels serious, then separate the frustration from the fix. — "Given the timing and the impact, I can see why this feels serious. Let's separate that from the next fix."

Partner worried they are too sensitive.

Anchor the reaction in shared history, then ask what would help. — "Given the history around that topic, it makes sense it lands with extra weight."

Leader debriefing team stress.

Normalise the reaction under ambiguity while keeping the decision live. — "A strong reaction is understandable under that much ambiguity. We still need to decide what to change."

Digital repair after an abrupt message.

Validate the misread, then clarify intent and repair the tone. — "I can see why that message felt abrupt. I don't mean to make that sound small."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- There is an immediate safety risk and action is needed before reassurance.
- The person is asking for accountability, and normalising would sound like excusing the harm.
- You do not yet understand enough context to normalise responsibly.
- The person needs a direct answer, boundary or decision rather than emotional support.
- Normalising would pressure them to accept poor treatment, stay silent, or lower a reasonable standard.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the cue

Write five real statements that carry a shame or overreaction cue, such as "I shouldn't care this much" or "maybe I'm being dramatic". Notice the exact words that signal self-doubt.

Day 2 — Break down the context

For each statement, name four things: the specific context, the reaction to normalise, the problem that must NOT be normalised, and a next-step question.

Day 3 — Build the three-line ladder

For each situation write a weak, a better and a careful (best) normaliser using: "Given [context], [reaction] makes sense. That doesn't mean [problem] is okay."

Day 4 — Cut the generic

Read each careful line aloud and delete any phrase that could apply to anyone. Keep only what is anchored to the specific situation.

Day 5 — Rehearse recovery

Practise the recovery lines aloud until they sound ordinary: "I don't mean 'normal' as in acceptable", "let me say that more carefully", "I'm not trying to shrink what happened."

Day 6 — Field test the minimum move

Use the minimum viable move once in a low-stakes conversation. Watch whether the person relaxes, corrects you, or elaborates.

Day 7 — Review and calibrate

Write down the cue you noticed, the phrase you used, the calibration cue you saw, and any recovery you needed. Name

one thing to adjust next time.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I normalise the reaction rather than the problem?
- Did I anchor the line in specific context, not a generic "that's normal"?
- Did I leave the person room to disagree with my read?
- Did I avoid excusing harm, bad behaviour or poor process?
- Did I leave space for practical next steps rather than stopping at reassurance?
- Did I stop after one or two lines instead of pushing the frame?